

Competitor Research Questions (Restaurant Website Focus)

1. First Impression & Positioning

What is the very first thing the site communicates?

- Sweetgreen: The site communicates a modular layout, reminds me of a bento box.
- Osaka Japanese Restaurant: This site communicates a high-class aesthetic.
- The Angry Jerk: The site looks like it is going for an edgy, energetic feel.

Is the cuisine immediately clear without reading?

- Sweetgreen: Yes, they serve healthy salad bowls, teas and juices generally (even the name is a good clue).
- Osaka Japanese Restaurant: Yes, this restaurant serves sushi.
- The Angry Jerk: Yes, this restaurant serves Caribbean cuisine. The name 'The Angry Jerk' insinuates a focus on jerk chicken.

Does the brand feel casual, upscale, or somewhere in between?

- Sweetgreen: The brand is modern in design and layout. I would say it is between casual(or homey) and upscale.
- Osaka Japanese Restaurant: This brand feels upscale.
- The Angry Jerk: The brand feels casual.

What emotion is the site trying to evoke?

- Sweetgreen: The site is trying to let the user know that health can be fun. Taste doesn't need to be sacrificed.
- Osaka Japanese Restaurant: This is trying to evoke a sense of competence. Sushi is a dish that needs to be handled with care because it can make people sick if it isn't prepared correctly. They are also more interested in getting you to dine in.
- The Angry Jerk: The restaurant evokes a feeling of passion, happiness and energy.

2. Navigation & Information Architecture

How many items are in the main nav?

- Sweetgreen: 8
- Osaka Japanese Restaurant: 5
- The Angry Jerk: 11

Is the menu easy to find in one click?

- Sweetgreen: Yes.
- Osaka Japanese Restaurant: Yes.
- The Angry Jerk: Yes.

Are reservations a button, a link, or hidden?

- Sweetgreen: The site doesn't have reservations in the traditional sense. You can:
 - Make an outpost with 25 or more people.
 - Get catering for events.
 - Order from home from a store near you.

- Osaka Japanese Restaurant: This site doesn't have reservations on the website. It can allow someone to contact them, though.
- The Angry Jerk: The site doesn't have reservations in the traditional sense. You can:
 - Order catering.
 - Have private parties provided for.

Do they use sticky navigation?

- Sweetgreen: Yes.
- Osaka Japanese Restaurant: Yes.
- The Angry Jerk: Yes.

Ask yourself:

Did I ever feel lost?

- Sweetgreen: Yes. The 'Outpost' tab in the nav bar was confusing because I thought that was just their locations tab, but then realised that they had a locations section and needed to read more in-depth to understand what an outpost was.
- Osaka Japanese Restaurant: No. Everything was simple. However, even though I knew I was on the menu, I felt like I was doomscrolling social media.
- The Angry Jerk: Not particularly. However, I feel like they could have consolidated the menu and drinks sections, and the catering and parties sections in the nav bar.

Did anything feel unnecessary?

- Sweetgreen: Yes. The 'Outpost' tab could have been joined with 'Catering' and just called 'Catering,' personally.
- Osaka Japanese Restaurant: No.
- The Angry Jerk: No.

3. Menu Presentation

Is the menu a PDF, page, tabs, or cards?

- Sweetgreen: The menu is a catalogue of cards.
- Osaka Japanese Restaurant: The menu wasn't a PDF; it was like a page - a wall of text (it has no photos on it). It doesn't use tabs or cards (at least it is not a reusable card; obviously, elements are organised in a specific way).
- The Angry Jerk: The menu was a list of items on the page. It is not intended to be interacted with and has typos.

Are categories clearly separated?

- Sweetgreen: Yes.
- Osaka Japanese Restaurant: Technically, yes. Soup is grouped differently from sashimi.
- The Angry Jerk: Yes.

Do they show prices immediately or hide them?

- Sweetgreen: No. They show the image, food name, food description and in some cases the nutritional process. You have to go through the full ordering process (which i didn't bother to do). I am not sure where they actually show the prices.
- Osaka Japanese Restaurant: Yes.
- The Angry Jerk: No. There are no prices there.

Do dishes feel scannable or overwhelming?

- Sweetgreen: The dishes feel scannable.
- Osaka Japanese Restaurant: The dishes are scannable, the amount of dishes on one page is what is overwhelming.
- The Angry Jerk: Yes.

Are special items highlighted (chef's picks, seasonal)?

- Sweetgreen: No, the only highlighted thing in the menu is whether or not it is an online only item. There are items that show up on the home page, but they don't have any sort of badge. They are broken into groups: salads, warm bowls and sides (though sides fades out gradually, insinuating that there is more info to the right, but the website doesn't let me horizontally scroll)
- Osaka Japanese Restaurant: No.
- The Angry Jerk: No.

Pay attention to:

How much info is shown per dish

- Sweetgreen: Some cards have just an image, some show the image, the dish name and description and, finally, the menu cards show the image, the dish name and description and the nutritional information.
- Osaka Japanese Restaurant: Each dish shows its name, its price and a short description.
- The Angry Jerk: Each dish only shows its name.

Whether images help or distract

- Sweetgreen: Images were mainly helpful.
- Osaka Japanese Restaurant: There are no images.
- The Angry Jerk: Each section has an image but the individual dishes do not. However, even those images appear in different places on each section, so it creates a sense of whiplash.

4. Calls to Action (CTAs)

What are the primary CTAs?

- Sweetgreen: The primary CTA is the 'Order' CTA.
- Osaka Japanese Restaurant: The primary CTA is the 'Contact Us' CTA.
- The Angry Jerk: The primary CTA is the 'Catering' CTA.

Where are they placed?

- Sweetgreen: It's in the nav bar.

- Osaka Japanese Restaurant: It's placed in the hero image on the top of the home page.
- The Angry Jerk: Throughout the home page.

Do they repeat or stay persistent?

- Sweetgreen: It stays persistent.
- Osaka Japanese Restaurant: It is a tab in the nav bar and then it is a CTA in the hero image so yes it repeats though it is just a regular link in the nav bar (not a CTA).
- The Angry Jerk: It repeats. And other CTAs show up as well.

Ask:

Is it obvious what the site wants me to do?

- Sweetgreen: It wants me to order online.
- Osaka Japanese Restaurant: It wants the user to go to their restaurant(s).
- The Angry Jerk: It isn't super obvious but I wouldn't say it is hard to decipher either. They feature the fact that they cater and they let you know you can order online (that isn't controlled by their site, though).

5. Visual Hierarchy & Layout

What grabs attention first?

- Sweetgreen: A large hero image/slideshow at the top of the home page.
- Osaka Japanese Restaurant: The photo in the hero image at the top of the home page.
- The Angry Jerk: A video at the top of the home page.

What comes second?

- Sweetgreen: A section of cards for various menu items in a straight line.
- Osaka Japanese Restaurant: The CTA buttons to contact them.
- The Angry Jerk: A section about their catering that animates into place. I thought that was a bit distracting.

Are sections clearly separated?

- Sweetgreen: Yes.
- Osaka Japanese Restaurant: Yes but in the menu the delineations are hard to see.
- The Angry Jerk: Yes.

Do they use full-width sections or contained layouts?

- Sweetgreen: Both.
- Osaka Japanese Restaurant: mainly full width but the menu and gallery are in columns
- The Angry Jerk: Both.

Is there intentional breathing room?

- Sweetgreen: Yes.
- Osaka Japanese Restaurant: Yes.
- The Angry Jerk: Yes.

6. Mobile Experience (Very Important)

Is the menu usable on mobile?

- Sweetgreen: Yes.
- Osaka Japanese Restaurant: Yes.
- The Angry Jerk: Yes but it scrolls horizontally when it doesn't need to.

Are buttons easy to tap?

- Sweetgreen: Yes.
- Osaka Japanese Restaurant: Yes.
- The Angry Jerk: Yes.

Does anything feel cramped or broken?

- Sweetgreen: The menu feels a bit cramped, but since the text is large and capitalized, i think thats intentional
- Osaka Japanese Restaurant: No.
- The Angry Jerk: The hamburger menu feels cramped beside the social media icons.

Do tabs or filters work well on small screens?

- Sweetgreen: There are no tabs or filters to speak of, really.
- Osaka Japanese Restaurant: There are no tabs or filters.
- The Angry Jerk: There areno tabs or filters.

7. Accessibility & Clarity

Is text readable over images/video?

- Sweetgreen: Yes.
- Osaka Japanese Restaurant: Yes.
- The Angry Jerk: Yes.

Are fonts large enough?

- Sweetgreen: Yes.
- Osaka Japanese Restaurant: Yes.
- The Angry Jerk: Yes.

Is color contrast strong?

- Sweetgreen: Yes.
- Osaka Japanese Restaurant: Yes.
- The Angry Jerk: Yes.

Does the site feel usable without sound?

- Sweetgreen: Yes. It doesn't depend on sound.

- Osaka Japanese Restaurant: Yes. It doesn't depend on sound.
- The Angry Jerk: Yes. It doesn't depend on sound.

You don't need WCAG numbers here. Just: "Would my mom understand this?"

- Sweetgreen: The design would be easy to understand, but it would become confusing when she tries to order something.
- Osaka Japanese Restaurant: The layout would be easy for my mother to understand, but she would be overwhelmed by the long menu.
- The Angry Jerk: Maybe, but she is picky and wouldn't like the name and wouldn't give it enough time to actually understand it.

8. Trust Signals

Do they show:

Reviews

- Sweetgreen: No.
- Osaka Japanese Restaurant: No.
- The Angry Jerk: Yes.

Awards

- Sweetgreen: No.
- Osaka Japanese Restaurant: No.
- The Angry Jerk: No.

Chef credibility

- Sweetgreen: No.
- Osaka Japanese Restaurant: No.
- The Angry Jerk: Yes.

Location info

- Sweetgreen: Yes.
- Osaka Japanese Restaurant: Yes.
- The Angry Jerk: Yes.

Does the site feel legitimate and polished?

- Sweetgreen: It feels legitimate and polished, but the style is not my preference.
- Osaka Japanese Restaurant: It feels like the company did the bare minimum in some ways. However, it isn't tacky looking. On the pages that have photos, the site looks a lot more polished.
- The Angry Jerk: Not really. It isn't awful, but the menu isn't interactive and has at least one typo. On top of that, some of the animation feels unnecessary.

9. Footer Content

What's in their footer?

- Sweetgreen:
 - About Us: Careers, Investor Relations, Locations, Press, sweetgreen app, The Hex Bowl
 - Social Media: Instagram, Twitter, Tik Tok, Spotify, Facebook
 - Support + Services: Contact Us, Gift Card, Store
 - Legal: Privacy Policy, Terms of Use, Your Privacy Choices, California Notice at Collection, Accessibility Statement, Consumer Health Data Notice
 - Sweetgreen copyright, Sweetgreen and the Hex Bowl trademark
- Osaka Japanese Restaurant: The footer only has the copyright information in the footer.
- The Angry Jerk: Locations, store hours, social media links, contact information and an accessibility link.

Is anything missing that you expect?

- Sweetgreen: No.
- Osaka Japanese Restaurant: Yes. I would have put things like store hours and pertinent legal information in the footer.
- The Angry Jerk: No.

Is it minimal or dense?

- Sweetgreen: The footer has a lot of info, but it is in simple lists, so it feels minimal.
- Osaka Japanese Restaurant: Minimal.
- The Angry Jerk: It is pretty dense. It isn't that there is a lot of information in the footer, but the chosen font size is big, though.

10. What Would You Steal (Ethically)

One layout idea you like

- Sweetgreen: I like the layout of the nav bar. The logo is in the centre, and the navigation and CTA are balanced on either side.
- Osaka Japanese Restaurant: I liked the hero image.
- The Angry Jerk: Yes. I liked the colour scheme.

One interaction you'd reuse

- Sweetgreen: Some of the cards can be flipped to show more information on the back. I liked the interactivity, and I would implement that.
- Osaka Japanese Restaurant: No interactions made me want to use them.
- The Angry Jerk: When the nav bar reaches the top, everything in it grows a little, making it grow slightly, and when it scrolls, it shrinks. I liked that.

One thing you would avoid completely

- Sweetgreen: Some things weren't named in an intuitive way, so I expected things that were elsewhere. Also, sometimes the text filled so much of the page, and I felt like I was constantly scrolling in places.
- Osaka Japanese Restaurant: I would avoid the layout of the menu entirely.
- The Angry Jerk: The overuse of animation and video. Along with unnecessary repetition of design elements like the logo.